

before he makes a decision.

This final check-out may require only a few minutes or even a few seconds, but it pays large dividends. It provides the individual with one final—and priceless—opportunity to arrange his thoughts in logical order and to refresh his memory as to why and how he arrived at his decision. This simple procedure greatly increases the individual's ability to instantly and convincingly counter any objections that may arise. It is, in a way, analogous to the habit formed by many of the world's finest actors who, although they may know their part in a play thoroughly, will nonetheless give the script or at least their lines a quick skimming over before the curtain goes up for a performance.

One of the most successful salesmen I have ever known—he is now a top sales executive in a giant corporation—maintains that he owes much of his success to having formed this habit early in his career.

"I even developed a sort of personal gimmick to form the habit," he told me. "When calling on an account, I invariably stopped off first to have a cup of coffee, get a shoe-shine or do something of the sort. This gave me a final chance to mentally review my presentation before actually setting foot in the customer's office. It worked wonders. I sold much more effectively and was always prepared to answer any questions or objections that arose."

There is no doubt about it—at least not in my mind: whether or not one needs a gimmick to do so, it is an excel-

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lent idea to form the habit of taking a last-minute mental breathing spell to organize one's thoughts before making decisions.

Another—albeit much less simple—habit that should be acquired by any man who wants to get ahead rapidly in business is the habit of being relaxed. The successful businessman is usually the one who is always relaxed—